greatest challenge to its control of them since 1945. Washington should acknowledge bluntly that China is contesting control not of the high seas, like Germany in World War I or Japan in World War II, but of the marginal seas and skies of Asia, even while the United States remains dominant on the high seas of the Pacific. Indeed, it is arguable that the Chinese military already can assert control over the waters and skies of the first island chain—in other words, the marginal seas and skies of eastern Asia. This control will make it difficult, perhaps impossible, to fight back into the region if US forces are dislodged or preemptively choose a posture of offshore balancing.

Recognizing this fact not only clarifies our understanding of Chinese military activity in the region but also maps out the area under risk and the geopolitical pivot of the Indo-Pacific: the Asiatic Mediterranean. The integrated waters of the Sea of Japan, the Yellow Sea, and the East and South China Seas are as vital to the history, identity, and trade of eastern Asia as the Mediterranean is to Europe. While it is geographically a stretch to connect the Asiatic Mediterranean to the Indian Ocean, the passageways between the two remain among the world's most vital waterways, through which one-third of global trade passes, in the form of over seventy thousand ships per year moving into the Asiatic Mediterranean.[18] The great factories and workshops of China, Japan, South Korea, Taiwan, Vietnam, and others, on which the global trading network depends, are located along the littoral of the Asiatic Mediterranean. It forms the hinge between maritime Eurasia and the entire Western Hemisphere. To return to Spykman's formulation, control of the Asiatic Mediterranean means control of Asia.

The challenge posed by China is thus twofold. It threatens the maritime and aerospace freedom of the Asiatic Mediterranean, and thus ultimately of Asia's productive and trading capacities. It also is positioning China to have a preponderance of power that can be brought against the Indo-Pacific's rimlands, as well as against what Spykman called the "outer crescent," which, in Asia, includes Japan, the Philippines, Indonesia, and Australia. These rimlands and the outer crescent, it should be remembered, are uniquely composed of continental,